NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 2NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠10

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠6

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣A

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠10

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥3

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A K 3
♥ 10 6
♦ A 6 5 2
♣ A 8 5 4

♠ Q 7 6 2
♥ J 9 5
♦ K J 9 7
♣ Q 10



♠ 10 9 8 4
♥ Q 8 2
♦ Q 10
♣ K J 9 7

♠ J 5
♥ A K 7 4 3
♦ 8 4 3
♣ 6 3 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♥	Pass	2NT
All Pass			

2NT by North
Lead: ♠10

Partner's 2♦ bid is a transfer so you bid 2♥. Partner now bids 2NT.

Partner's 2♦ bid is a transfer so you bid 2♥. Partner now bids 2NT.

Partner is describing an invitational hand (9-10 points) with a 5-card ♥ suit. With a bare 15 points and doubleton ♥ you just pass.

East leads the ♠10 against your 2NT.

You try dummy's ♠J hopefully, but West puts on the ♠Q.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 6

You must find two more winners. And you have very little to work with. In fact, the only real chance you have is to establish dummy's ♥ suit.

You must find the ♥s split 3-3. Even then, with no entries in dummy outside the ♥ suit you cannot afford to play ♥ A K followed by a third one. True, the suit would be established, but you could never get to it.

So you win the first trick with your ♠K, then play a ♥, ducking in dummy.

An opponent will win the ♥, but whatever they return you win one of your Aces. Then play your last ♥ to dummy. If the suit splits you will make 4 ♥ tricks to go with your 4 other top honors.

You were very lucky to find a 3-3 ♥ split. This happens only about 40% of the time.

But if you had not made the correct plan your good fortune would have been wasted.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ J 3 ♥ J 10 9 2 ♦ J 9 8 4 ♣ Q J 9	
♠ 7 5 2 ♥ A Q 6 ♦ A Q 6 5 3 ♣ 7 3	N W E S	♠ K Q 9 ♥ K 7 5 4 ♦ K 10 ♣ A 8 4 2
	♠ A 10 8 6 4 ♥ 8 3 ♦ 7 2 ♣ K 10 6 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♠6

You don't have enough points to be thinking about slam and you don't particularly want to play 5♦. So you bid 3NT and everybody passes.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♠6; North plays the ♠J.

Your immediate problem is whether or not to hold up. ? ? ?

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 8

There is some merit in a holdup. North is likely to have just 2 ♠s, so a holdup would exhaust his cards in the suit. If he later got the lead he would have no ♠s. On the other hand, North might well switch to ♣s, and that would certainly be unwelcome. Finally, if you do win the first ♠ you have another stopper if you can prevent North from getting the lead. So win the first trick with the ♠K. Notice that by winning with the ♠K you keep South in the dark as to whether you or North has the ♠Q.

You need just one more trick, and either red suit might split 3-3. So is that your plan? Lead out red winners and hope?

Truthfully, that wouldn't be a terrible plan. The chance of a 3-3 split in a suit is about 36%. But since you need either of two 36% chances that comes to almost 60% (if you aren't Math oriented don't worry about it, you can trust me).

There's a safer approach though; remember you only need 4 ♦ tricks, not 5.

There is a wonderful "safety play" that will practically guarantee your contract. Enter dummy with a ♥, then play a small ♦ toward your hand and finesse with your ♦10! South may win with the ♦J, but even if he does he is the Safe Hand and cannot play a ♠ without giving you a trick. And whatever else he could play you would win and make 4 ♦ tricks. In the actual Deal the ♦ finesse actually works and you make all 5 tricks in the suit.

The only way this plan could go wrong is if South held the singleton ♦J. And if that were the case you wouldn't make the contract anyway (unless ♥s were 3-3).

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ K J 7 3 ♥ A 6 3 ♦ K J 9 2 ♣ 10 4	
♠ 8 4 ♥ J 10 9 7 ♦ 10 5 3 ♣ A K 7 5	N W E S	♠ Q 10 2 ♥ 8 5 ♦ Q 6 4 ♣ J 9 6 3 2
	♠ A 9 6 5 ♥ K Q 4 2 ♦ A 8 7 ♣ Q 8	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	3NT	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♣A

With both Majors, the correct response to Stayman is 2♥. Partner now bids 3NT.

With both Majors, the correct response to Stayman is 2♥. Partner now bids 3NT.

Partner denies having 4 ♥s so obviously he must hold 4 ♠s. You therefore correct the contract to 4♠, your known 4-4 Major fit.

South plays 4♠. West takes two top ♣s, then leads the ♥J.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 4

There are lots of possibilities for getting rid of one loser. The ♠Q might drop, or she might be in the West hand, finessable. The ♥s might split 3-3, providing for the discard of a ♦ loser. West might hold the ♦Q so that finesse works.

Suppose you win the ♥ in your hand and try the ♠ finesse. If East has the ♠Q you will then have to find the ♥s splitting, which is not likely, or the ♦Q in the West hand.

A better plan would be to shun the trump Queen finesse entirely. Play the ♠K, then ♠A. If the ♠Q falls then pull the last trump and you are home free.

If the ♠Q DOESN'T fall, play your other two ♥ winners. When East discards on the last ♥ you exit with a small trump to a defender's ♠Q.

If West wins the ♠ you will just have to depend on the ♦ finesse. But if East takes the trick he will be endplayed, having to give you a ruff/sluff in ♣s, or lead into dummy's ♦ K J.

This plan combines several chances.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

♠ A 10 9 8 3
♥ 9 8 3
♦ K J 5
♣ 6 2

♠ K 6 4
♥ K 5
♦ A 9 7 6 2
♣ A Q 4



♠ J 7
♥ A Q 7 2
♦ 8 3
♣ J 10 9 7 5

♠ Q 5 2
♥ J 10 6 4
♦ Q 10 4
♣ K 8 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♦	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♠10

With 9 points you are in the game-invitational range. And with a 4-card ♥ suit you should use Stayman. You bid 2♣ and partner says 2♦. What is your next bid?

With 9 points you are in the game-invitational range. And with a 4-card ♥ suit you should use Stayman. You bid 2♣ and partner says 2♦. What is your next bid?

You are still in game-invitational range, but now you invite partner with 2NT. He replies 3NT and that ends the bidding.

The contract would be 3NT played by East.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♠10. You cross your fingers and put on dummy's ♠J. No good, South covers with the ♠Q and you are forced to take your ♠K at the first trick.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 6

Not only do you need 3 more winners, you need to get them without losing the lead because the instant you lose the lead North will take all his ♠ winners. You can **HOPE** that will only be 3 of them but you can't depend on it.

The ♣ suit is your only hope. If South holds the ♣K you can finesse him out of it. However, if he has ♣ K x x and refuses to cover your ♣J, you will have to have a second entry to dummy to cash the good ♣s.

As it happens, you do have two entries, the ♥A and ♥Q! You just have to sacrifice your ♥K to use them both. At trick 2 play your small ♥ to the ♥Q. Play the ♣J, letting it ride when South plays low. Play a small ♣ to your ♣Q. Play the ♣A, dropping South's ♣K. And finally, play your ♥K to dummy's ♥A so you can enjoy cashing those two good ♣s.

Bridge is a nice game.

You sacrifice one sure ♥ winner to create a second dummy entry which creates two ♣ winners.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A Q 10 8 ♥ A 2 ♦ K 10 9 ♣ Q J 10 4	
♠ 7 5 2 ♥ Q J 9 4 ♦ 8 5 4 ♣ A 8 5	N W E S	♠ K 6 3 ♥ K 10 6 3 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ 9 7 2
	♠ J 9 4 ♥ 8 7 5 ♦ A Q J 2 ♣ K 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥3

Partner has about 11 points and he has no 4-card Major suit.

He thinks 3NT would be a good spot. You have no reason to disagree so you pass.

North plays 3NT; East leads the ♥3.

West plays the ♥J and you duck, hoping he will switch to any other suit! But of course he doesn't; he continues with the ♥4.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 4 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 6

You need three more winners. You can get them in ♣s by just driving out the ♣A. The danger is that EW might win the ♣A and 4 ♥ tricks. Or, you can get them in ♠s if West holds the ♠K, a 50% chance.

You should try to avoid 50% chances when you have something better. Consider the chance that EW will actually be able to win 4 ♥ tricks if you give them the lead with the ♣A. In particular notice that you were dealt the ♥2! If East's ♥3 is a fourth down lead then he cannot have anything smaller and the ♥s are splitting 4-4.

Knowing they can only take 3 ♥ tricks makes it safe for you to drive out the ♣A.

So win the ♥A and drive out the ♣A. They will take their 2 ♥ tricks next. If West then leads a ♠ **DO NOT FINESSE**. Take your nine tricks and run.

The question to consider about this Deal is whether to trust your opponents, in particular whether you can trust them to be leading fourth highest.

While the answer may depend on the opponent, usually you should take their opening lead at face value. After all, their main goal is to give information to their partner, not to deceive you.